

33-year-old has trained at the NCA and the CoE after multiple injuries, the most threatening being after the iconic Gabba Test in 2021, where he bowled a spell through a hamstring strain.

“When you go back after an injury, it’s not like you are bowling 140 or at the same level as before the injury. The first day after injury, you start from zero. And you have to push yourself so much to go back to your peak level. At that time, only your physio or trainer has the most important role. Because as a player, there is little doubt. You also fear getting injured again. So, at that time, only the trainer knows how to prepare the player,” Saini adds.

Given India’s busy schedule and the grand expectations of success placed on those who run the affairs, it is not hard to fathom that at some point, some player must have been rushed back into the team. Recently,

news reports claimed that pacer Harshit was brought back before the completion of the stipulated recovery time.

Elsewhere, though, Australia’s decision not to field Cummins in four of the five 2025-26 Ashes Tests sets the right example here — keeping the player’s welfare before the team’s need, even for arguably the most-billed event in Australian sport.

Finding the right mix

Yet, the decision around the players’ workload and return falls on the players themselves too.

Saini adds that working towards one’s fitness does not stop outside the field. At a time when State T20 leagues have practically eaten into the off-season in Indian cricket, recovery during acute workload should be the priority for any player.

Take Saini, for example. After the domestic season with Delhi, he joined Kolkata Knight Riders for the

IPL, then went to England for County cricket and finally came back to play in the DPL. Once the T20 tournament is done with, preparations start for the domestic season.

“If you want to take the off-season, then you have time to recover. But it is the player’s choice. You don’t want to miss matches either. If you have a mindset to play, then your body works accordingly. For me, the same routine is still going on. But now there is more focus on recovery, diet and sleep. If you start doing this at the age of 20 or 22 years old, you will be even better because you have been preparing your body for 10-12 years. Take Mitchell Starc, for example. We have seen that he still plays almost all Tests. He has been playing cricket all year. I think he is 37 now [36]. If he can do so much, why can’t we?” Saini says.

Saini pointed to the impressive

Big three, big woes (list of injuries since July 2024)

INDIA

Player	Injury	Date
Tilak Varma	Wrist	Jul 2024
Shivam Dube	Back	Oct 2024
Mayank Yadav	Side strain	May 2024
Riyan Parag	Shoulder	Nov 2024
Kuldeep Yadav	Groin	Nov 2024
Jasprit Bumrah	Back	Feb 2025
Nitish Kumar Reddy	Knee	Jul 2025
Arshdeep Singh	Thumb	Jul 2025
Rishabh Pant	Foot	Jul 2025
Akash Deep	Groin	Jul 2025
Hardik Pandya	Quadriceps	Sep 2025
Nitish Kumar Reddy	Quadriceps	Oct 2025
Shreyas Iyer	Rib	Oct 2025
Shubman Gill	Neck	Nov 2025
Rishabh Pant	Side strain	Jan 2026
Tilak Varma	Testicular torsion	Jan 2026
Washington Sundar	Side strain	Jan 2026
Harshit Rana	Knee	Jan 2026
Varun Chakaravathy	Foot	Apr 2026
Virat Kohli	Hamstring	May 2026
Hardik Pandya	Back / Quadriceps	Jun 2026
Nitish Kumar Reddy	Quadriceps	Jun 2026
Washington Sundar	Hamstring	Jul 2026
Jasprit Bumrah	Knee	Jul 2026
Sai Sudharsan	Toe	Jul 2026

AUSTRALIA

Player	Injury	Date
Cameron Green	Back	Sep 2024
Josh Hazlewood	Calf strain	Aug 2024
Nathan Ellis	Hamstring	Aug 2024
Spencer Johnson	Side strain	Sep 2024
Ben Dwarshuis	Pectoral	Sep 2024
Michael Naser	Hamstring	Nov 2024
Josh Hazlewood	Calf	Dec 2024
Mitchell Marsh	Back	Dec 2024
Pat Cummins	Ankle	Jan 2025
Steve Smith	Elbow	Jan 2025
Mitchell Marsh	Back	Feb 2025
Josh Hazlewood	Hip	Feb 2025
Steve Smith	Finger	Jun 2025
Pat Cummins	Back	Jul 2025
Sean Abbott	Hamstring	Nov 2025
Josh Hazlewood	Hamstring	Nov 2025
Usman Khawaja	Back spasms	Nov 2025
Nathan Lyon	Hamstring	Dec 2025
Josh Hazlewood	Achilles	Dec 2025
Tim David	Hamstring	Dec 2025
Nathan Ellis	Hamstring	Mar 2026
Mitchell Starc	Shoulder/elbow	Mar 2026
Cameron Green	Lower-back	Apr 2026
Mitchell Marsh	Ankle	May 2026
Michael Naser	Calf	Aug 2026

ENGLAND

Player	Injury	Date
Zak Crawley	Finger	Aug 2024
Ben Stokes	Hamstring	Aug 2024
Mark Wood	Thigh	Aug 2024
Mark Wood	Elbow	Sep 2024
Jos Buttler	Calf	Sep 2024
Josh Hull	Quadriceps	Sep 2024
Ben Stokes	Hamstring	Dec 2024
Mark Wood	Knee	Feb 2025
Olly Stone	Knee	Apr 2025
Jofra Archer	Thumb	May 2025
Gus Atkinson	Hamstring	May 2025
Jamie Overton	Finger	May 2025
Ben Stokes	Shoulder	Jul 2025
Chris Woakes	Shoulder	Jul 2025
Mark Wood	Hamstring	Nov 2025
Jofra Archer	Side strain	Dec 2025
Mark Wood	Knee	Dec 2025
Gus Atkinson	Hamstring	Dec 2025
Ben Stokes	Groin	Jan 2026
Ben Stokes	Face	Feb 2026
Brydon Carse	Hand	Apr 2026
Jacob Bethell	Knee	Jul 2026
Emilio Gay	Shoulder	Aug 2026
Sam Curran	Groin	Aug 2026
Will Jacks	Appendix	Aug 2026